

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

In the second week of April, the playground was crowded, and somebody bumped into Sofia.

The somebody was a kid named Wyatt, from one of the second-grade classes. Wyatt did not look back. Wyatt kept running. Wyatt did not apologize.

Sofia stood for a moment, holding her elbow where Wyatt had hit it, and her first thought — the thought her brain handed her — was: Wyatt did that on purpose. Wyatt does not like me. Wyatt is mean.

She walked back to her class, mad.

That afternoon, when Ms. Calloway said the lesson was about the Pause Practice, Sofia paid extra attention.

"Friends," said Sammy. "Today we are going to talk about a thing your brain does in about one second, that you have to learn to slow down. Are you ready?"

The kids nodded.

"When somebody does something to you — bumps into you, doesn't text back, doesn't say hi, looks at you funny, leaves you out — your brain is very, very fast. Your brain takes about one second to give you a STORY about what just happened. And the story your brain gives you is almost always — they did it on purpose. They do not like me. They are mean." "That is the FAST story. The fast story is your brain trying to protect you. Your brain thinks, I have to figure out who is the enemy, fast,

so I can stay safe. That is your brain's job. Your brain is not bad." "BUT — and this is the important but — the fast story is almost always WRONG. The fast story is almost never the actual reason. Most of the time, the actual reason is something boring. They didn't see you. They were thinking about something else. They were having a hard day. They thought you were mad at them. Their phone was off. They forgot." "Today we are going to learn the Pause Practice. Before you decide what the story is, you pause. You ask yourself: what is the kindest possible reason this happened? You imagine three different reasons. Then you pick the kindest one. You pick the kindest one because most of the time the kindest one is also the most true."

Sammy held up the chart.

THE PAUSE PRACTICE

Something happens. → I notice my fast story. → I pause. → I think of THREE OTHER reasons. → I pick the kindest one. → I move on.

Sofia raised her hand.

"What if the kindest one is wrong?"

"Then you find out it is wrong. And then you adjust. But most of the time the kindest one is right. So you waste a lot less energy being mad, if you pick the kindest one first."

Sofia thought about Wyatt.

What was her fast story? Wyatt did that on purpose. Wyatt is mean. What were three other reasons?

1. Wyatt did not see me.
2. Wyatt was running fast and could not stop.
3. Wyatt was already in trouble for something and was trying not to get in more trouble.

Which was the kindest?

Probably number 1. Wyatt did not see her.

She felt her shoulders un-tense.

After school, she happened to pass Wyatt in the hallway. Wyatt looked up.

"Hi, Sofia," he said. "Sorry I bumped into you at recess. I did not see you. Are you okay?"

Sofia looked at him.

"I am fine," she said. "Thank you."

She walked the rest of the way to the bus thinking about how she had been mad at Wyatt all afternoon for nothing. Wyatt had not seen her. Wyatt was sorry. The whole story she had been telling herself — Wyatt is mean to me, Wyatt does not like me — had been wrong, the entire time. This is the Pause Practice. It saves you, on average, about eight unnecessary mad feelings per day. Multiply that by 365. Multiply that by a lifetime. The amount of unnecessary mad-feelings you save yourself, across a lifetime, by doing the Pause Practice — is more energy than you can imagine. That energy gets to go to other things. Better things. Sofia is going to do the Pause Practice for the rest of her life, in different forms, sometimes well and sometimes not. But the idea — the muscle — she got it in first grade, in April, on the day after Wyatt bumped into her on the playground.

Worth the whole year, just for that.